

PRODUCT PROTOTYPE GUIDE

Experimentation, Personalization & Recommendation

A tour of what's been built, how to explore it yourself, and how each piece actually works underneath.

LIVE DEMO

<https://payload-admin-experimentation.vercel.app/>

This is not Payload CMS — see the next page for what it actually is.

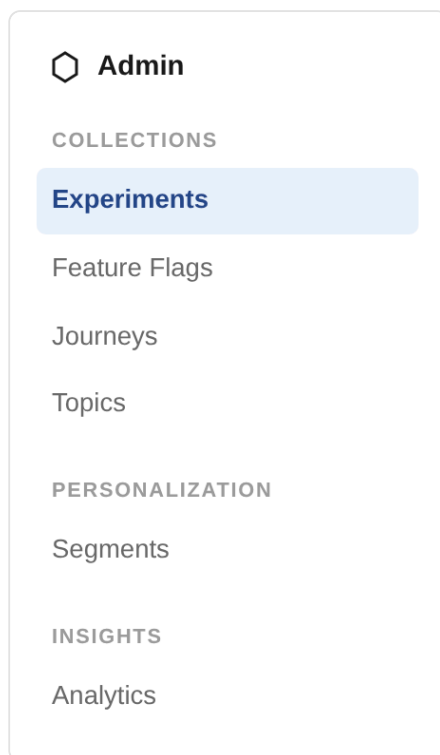
Read this first: what this actually is

This is not Payload CMS. It's a prototype built to look and feel like the real Payload admin — same layout, same components, same visual language — so the team can click through a concrete version of the Personalization, Recommendation, and Experimentation concepts before committing to building them for real. Under the hood it's a small standalone app with no relation to the actual Payload codebase.

What it is *not* a prototype of: the GrowthBook connection is real, and this live link is actually connected to it. Hitting "Sync to GrowthBook" on a personalized block or an experiment makes a genuine API call to a real GrowthBook account — creating and updating real Features there, not returning canned responses. The sidebar shows "Connected to GrowthBook" for exactly this reason — it isn't a mock status.

Data lives in the browser's local storage, not a shared server — everyone who opens the link gets their own independent copy of the sample data.

Navigation overview



The sidebar — three groups: Collections, Personalization, Insights.

Three groups in the sidebar: **Collections** (Experiments, Feature Flags, Journeys, Topics), **Personalization** (Segments), and **Insights** (Analytics). The three concepts below map onto this structure.

1 Experimentation (A/B testing)

[Collections](#) → [Experiments](#)

Classic A/B/n testing: two or more variants, a traffic-split weight per variant, a stated hypothesis, a primary and secondary metric, and results pulled in as a chart and table. A visitor's variant is decided **randomly** — the whole point is to measure which one performs better.

Admin

COLLECTIONS

Experiments

Feature Flags

Journeys

Topics

PERSONALIZATION

Segments

INSIGHTS

Analytics

Experiments

Create New

Search by Name

Columns Filters

Name	Status	GrowthBook Sync	Updated
Homepage CTA — anxiety vs. belonging messaging 2 variants	Live	Synced	28 Jul at 14:44
World Cup geofenced homepage test 3 variants	Draft	Not synced	28 Jul at 20:14
Pause Experience — timer length 2 variants	Paused	Error	27 Jul at 22:10

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Connected to GrowthBook

Reset sample data

The Experiments collection — status and GrowthBook sync state at a glance.

Open one and you get the full editor: variants, metrics, analysis settings, which journeys it applies to, a Versions history, an API tab, and a GrowthBook Sync panel.

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Analytics

Experiments / Homepage CTA — anxiety vs. belonging messaging

Homepage CTA — anxiety vs. belonging messaging

Edit

Versions 3

API

Status: Live

Last Modified: 28 Jul 2026, 2:44 PM

Created: 2 Jun at 15:30

Save Draft

Publish changes

Hypothesis

Visitors who arrive from an anxiety-themed ad convert better on a starting journey framed around calm and stillness, rather than the default belonging-framed journey everyone else sees.

What are we testing, and what do we expect to happen?

Variants — name, traffic split, and description are all editable

Control — default belonging framing

Current homepage, shown to all traffic today.

CONTROL

50 %

×

Anxiety-ad variant

Shown only to visitors whose entry campaign parameter matches an anxiety-themed ad.

Make control

50 %

×

+ Add variant

Metrics

Primary goal metric

Journey Start Rate

Secondary metrics

Journey Completion Rate

Time on Homepage

+ Add metric

Analysis settings

Difference type

Relative

Dimension

None

Content this applies to

journey The Path of Stillness

journey The Path of Presence

+ Link a journey...

Results — pulled from GrowthBook, read-only

CONVERSION RATE BY VARIANT

Control — default belonging framing

18.2%

Anxiety-ad variant Winner

23.6%

VARIANT	VISITORS	CONV. RATE	LIFT VS. CONTROL
Control — default belonging framing	4,230	18.2%	—
Anxiety-ad variant Winner	4,190	23.6%	+29.7%

8,420 total visitors assigned · 97% chance to beat control [Refresh from GrowthBook](#)

Status

Live

Linked feature flag

ff-homepage-cta-messaging

Which Feature Flag this experiment's traffic is served through

GrowthBook Sync

Status

Synced

Key: homepage-cta-anxiety-vs-belonging

Last synced: 28 Jul at 14:44

Synced to GrowthBook.

Sync to GrowthBook

Connected to GrowthBook

Reset sample data

Fields, list, and status chrome are styled to match this project's actual Payload admin (captured directly from the running instance). Changes here really do persist — in your browser's local storage — so edits, new experiments, and deletions all survive a page reload.

Experiment detail — hypothesis, variants, results, and the sync panel.

How it reaches GrowthBook: an Experiment becomes a GrowthBook Feature whose value is split randomly across variants — standard A/B testing mechanics.

2 Personalization

[Journeys](#) → [Content Blocks, and Personalization](#) → [Segments](#)

This is the deliberate opposite of an A/B test: **not random**. A block's content is chosen based on who the visitor actually is — their geography, device, or the campaign they arrived from.

A journey is built from content blocks. Any block can be personalized — switch it on and it reveals an **assignment policy**: an ordered list of Segment → Variant rules (each with its own headline, media, and copy), plus a required default shown to anyone matching none of them.

Not random — a visitor's segment (geo, device, referral...) deliberately decides which variant of a block they see, via the assignment policy on that block above. Manage reusable segments on the [Segments](#) page.

Hero

personalized

Remove

Headline

A space to be still

Subhead

What does your world look like right now?

Media

Ocean horizon, slow motion

Personalize this block

Assignment policy

Ordered — the first matching segment wins. Anyone matching none of these sees the default below.

Entered via Anxiety ad

→

anxiety-arm

Headline

A space to breathe

Subhead

When anxiety crowds in, is there room to exhale?

Media

Close-up: a hand steadying on a railing

India (Geo)

→

india-arm

Headline

A space to belong

Subhead

What does home feel like, wherever you are?

Media

Warm interior light, family silhouette

Mobile devices

→

mobile-arm

Headline

A space to be still

Subhead

Take a breath. Just for a moment.

Media

Vertical crop, ocean horizon

+ Add segment...

Default / fallback — shown when no rule matches

Headline

A space to be still

Subhead

What does your world look like right now?

Media

Ocean horizon, slow motion

GrowthBook Sync

Status

Synced

Key: `journey-stillness-hero`

Last synced: 28 Jul at 20:50

Synced to GrowthBook.

Sync to GrowthBook

Rules preview (GrowthBook payload)

Text

Body

Discover inner peace through the ancient practice of meditation and mindful breathing.

☐ Personalize this block

Rotating prayer (dynamic)

Pulls a random prayer submitted by another visitor on every page load. This is resolved dynamically at request time — a different mechanism from segment-based personalization, so it isn't personalizable here.
Dynamic block — resolved at request time from a rotating pool, not personalizable by segment.

Next step choice

Continue to The Path of Presence

Continue to The Path of Compassion

☐ Personalize this block

+ Add block...

A personalized Hero block — three segment-based rules plus a default fallback, with a live GrowthBook Sync panel.

The populations referenced above ("Entered via Anxiety ad," "India," "Mobile devices") are **Segments** — defined once, reused across any number of blocks.

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Connected to GrowthBook

Reset sample data

Segments

Create New

A segment defines who — geography, device, network, referral/campaign — not what they see. Reference a segment from a personalized content block's assignment policy to decide which variant that population gets.

Name	Category	Rule	Used by
India (Geo)	Geography	country equals "IN"	1 block
Soccer-heavy markets	Geography	country is one of (comma-separated) "BR, AR, MX, ES, IT"	1 block
Mobile devices	Device	deviceType equals "mobile"	2 blocks
Entered via Anxiety ad	Referral / campaign	utm_campaign equals "anxiety"	2 blocks
Entered via Belonging ad	Referral / campaign	utm_campaign equals "belonging"	1 block
Corporate / institutional network	Network	ipType equals "corporate"	Unused

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Segments — reusable visitor-population definitions, each with a plain-language rule.

How it reaches GrowthBook: a personalization policy becomes a string-valued GrowthBook Feature whose value comes from ordered `force` rules — each rule's condition is generated directly from a Segment's rule, and it deterministically forces one variant. The "Rules preview" panel shows the exact payload:

▼ Rules preview (GrowthBook payload)

```
{
  "id": "journey-stillness-hero",
  "valueType": "string",
  "defaultValue": "default-arm",
  "description": "Personalization policy for \"Opening hero\" on The Path of Stillness",
  "tags": [
    "personalization"
  ],
  "rules": [
    {
      "type": "force",
      "value": "anxiety-arm",
      "condition": {
        "utm_campaign": "anxiety"
      },
      "description": "Entered via Anxiety ad",
      "allEnvironments": true
    },
    {
      "type": "force",
      "value": "india-arm",
      "condition": {
        "country": "IN"
      },
    },
  ],
}
```

The exact GrowthBook Feature payload a personalization policy maps to.

Same delivery mechanism as an Experiment (a GrowthBook Feature), different assignment logic — deterministic instead of random.

3 Recommendation

Collections → Topics, and the "Related content" panel on any Journey

A third, independent mechanism — it doesn't touch GrowthBook at all. **Topics** are a content taxonomy: tags describing what a piece of content is about (Stillness, Anxiety, Presence, Compassion, Belonging, Grief), completely separate from Segments, which describe who's looking.

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Create New

A shared taxonomy across content pillars — a topic classifies content ("this journey is about grief"), independent of Segments (which classify visitors). Today only Journeys carry topics; Stories and Connect would tag into this same list once those pillars exist, which is what makes cross-pillar related-content lookups work.

Name	Slug	Tagged content
Stillness	stillness	The Path of Stillness
Anxiety	anxiety	The Path of Stillness
Presence	presence	The Path of Presence
Compassion	compassion	The Path of Compassion
Belonging	belonging	The Path of Compassion
Grief	grief	Unused

1–6 of 6 Per Page: 10

Connected to GrowthBook

Reset sample data

The Topics taxonomy, and which content each topic is currently tagged on.

Tag a journey with one or more topics, and any other journey sharing at least one topic automatically surfaces in its **Related content** panel — that's the recommendation mechanism.

Slug*

compassion

SEO

Title

Defaults to journey title if emp

Topics — content taxonomy, cross-pillar

Compassion ×

Belonging ×

Stillness ×

+ Tag topic... ▼

Independent of Segments — a topic says what this content is *about*, not who sees it. Shared with any future Stories/Connect pillar. Manage the full list on [Topics](#).

Related content — by shared topic

journey The Path of Stillness

[View →](#)

Matched by shared Topic tags. A Stories or Connect pillar would appear here too, once those collections exist.

Experiments — random split (A/B/n)

This journey is referenced by 1 experiment in the Experiments collection.

Pause Experience timer length

Paused

Topics tagged on a journey, and another journey surfaced automatically via a shared topic.

Today this only surfaces other Journeys, since that's the only content type built so far — but it's built so any future content type could tag into the same Topics list and start showing up here too, without changing how the lookup itself works.

The three, side by side

	EXPERIMENTATION	PERSONALIZATION	RECOMMENDATION
Question it answers	Which version performs better?	What should this visitor see?	What else is relevant to this content?
Assignment	Random	Deliberate, rule-based	Tag-based lookup
Driven by	Traffic-split weights	Segments	Topics
Talks to GrowthBook?	Yes — random-split Feature	Yes — rule-based Feature	No — stays inside the CMS

Everything else in here

- **Feature Flags** (Collections → Feature Flags) — plain on/off switches per environment, sometimes linked to an Experiment, sometimes standalone.
- **Analytics** (Insights → Analytics) — a read-only sample dashboard; in a real build this would embed GrowthBook's own analytics.
- **Reset sample data** (bottom of the sidebar) — wipes any edits made while exploring and restores the original sample data.

Live demo: <https://payload-admin-experimentation.vercel.app/>